

Rules in a Ten Simple Rules article

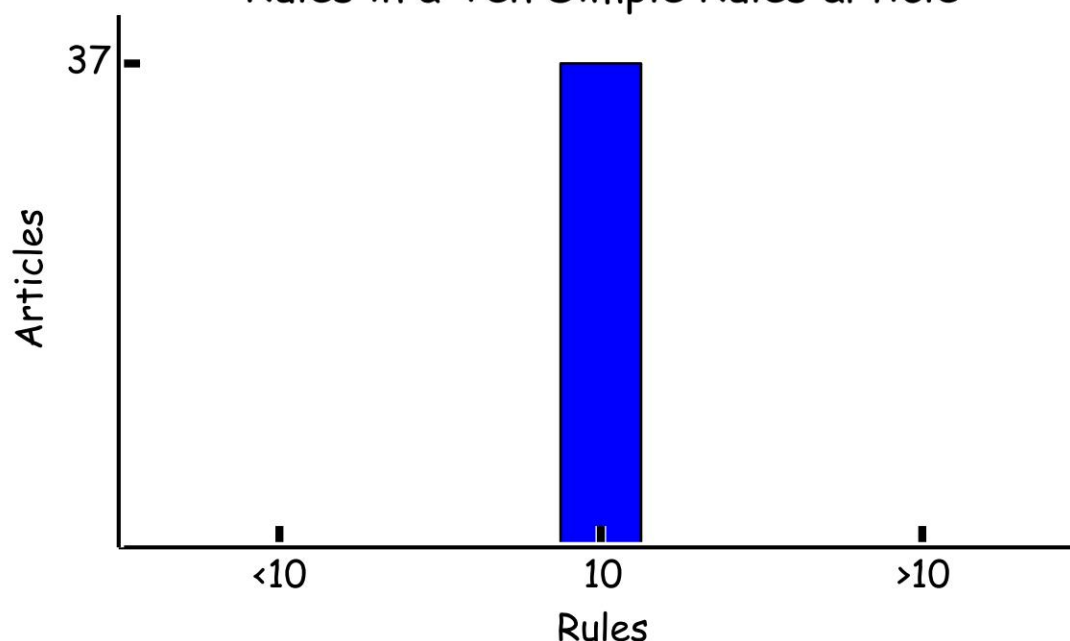


Figure 1. Have ten rules.

doi:10.1371/journal.pcbi.1003858.g001

tween academia and industry, and how to start a company. The articles even extend to interpersonal skills like networking, collaboration, and communicating with your supervisor. There is also a strong academic focus: the core skills of doing research, writing, publishing, and teaching.

Now, what can you add to the mix? What do you wish that you'd known a year ago? What would you tell a new student? What do you wish your supervisor would realise? Computational biology is such a fresh, fast-moving field. There is always room for advice to emerge and for those new to the field to share their experiences, drawing from other disciplines and bringing together emerging ideas and techniques. The Ten Simple Rules collection is a reservoir for accessible wisdom (in both the open source and intellectually approachable senses of the word). What do you have to contribute?

If you are stumped, here are some suggestions: Ten Simple Rules for retiring when you know you should. Ten Simple Rules for winning a Nobel Prize. Ten Simple Rules for managing a scientific rivalry.

[PB: Some would say I should write the first; none would say I should write the second; the third I have enough of already, but having an entry in the series from a Nobel laureate is a great idea—I am working on recruiting that someone right now—and so the series goes.]

Rule 3: Include an Introduction

Never underestimate the importance of a great introduction. Your introduction defines the scope of your article. It sets up a promise to your reader that you will cover this, that, but not some other thing. It provides the opportunity to put your topic in perspective and fill any gaps in your reader's knowledge.

Perhaps the most vital function of the introduction is to convince your reader to keep reading. You need to make your point clearly and simply the first time. You are also going to need to catch their attention in the first paragraph or so. You must convince them that you can both entertain and inform.

Like your Ten Simple Rules, your introduction should be short and to the point—there is no point having Ten Simple Rules with a thesis-length introduction.

[PB: Agreed, particularly concerning the length of the introduction.]

Rule 4: Be Philip E. Bourne

Your best chance of having a PLOS Ten Simple Rules article published is by being Philip E. Bourne. At the time of writing, 48.6% of PLOS Ten Simple Rules articles list *PLOS Computational Biology* Founding Editor-in-Chief, Philip E. Bourne, as the first, last, or sole author (Figure 2). In fact, statistically speaking

(Box 1), his frequent occurrences as an author of Ten Simple Rules is significant (p-value = 6.63758e-52).

More recent articles are increasingly written by other experts or groups of individuals, but Philip is often found as part of the author list. Before you start filling out a change of name form though, consider asking Philip to be a coauthor.

[PB: And I thought they asked me because I know something.]

Rule 5: Collaborate

You have a great idea for a Ten Simple Rules article, now you need to make it a reality. We have discussed getting Philip Bourne involved (see Rule 4), but we haven't yet discussed why having a coauthor or two could help, even if they don't have an in at PLOS.

When you write a Ten Simple Rules article, you are speaking with an aura of knowledge and authority. One way to achieve this is to be a giant in your field. But if only the "experts" write these articles, we are missing out on the intimate, hard-earned knowledge of those in the trenches. If your name doesn't strike awe in your readers, perhaps consider combining forces with others. If you can't find experts, contact your peers. The emerging opinion of a group of more junior authors may be almost as respect-